IN THEIR SIGHTS

PROPOSED AMENDMENTS TO THE WILDLIFE PROTECTION ACT COULD MAKE IT EASIER FOR CULLS TO TAKE PLACE. SOME WANT TO TAKE IT A STEP FURTHER AND LEGALISE HUNTING IN INDIA

By Rahul Noronha



For the past half century, India's natural world has been governed by the Wild Life (Protection) Act, 1972 (WPA), a broad legislation that covers everything from protected areas and wildlife crimes to hunting and legal safeguards for various species. It has been amended many times, with a latest round of revision in late 2021, when the Ministry of Environment, Forests and Climate Change invited public comments and proposals on a new draft amendment. One of the ministry's proposals was to ease restrictions on declaring certain species as 'vermin', without which culls of dangerous animals cannot be conducted (see *Culling a History*). Though this was a narrow, specific proposal, the public comments showed opinions fiercely divided over the core idea—hunting.

Some public proposals to the ministry's amendment seek relaxed restrictions on hunting, and have sparked especially fierce debate. (India has had a broad ban on hunting since 1972, when the WPA was enacted.) Those in favour point out that many countries allow it, and say it could be a source of revenue through the sale of hunting licences. They also say current bans on hunting are a result of politics. Broadly, there are two lines of support—rural Indians like farmers, for whom man-animal conflict is a frequent reality, and those who see hunting as a route to revenue.

H.S. Pabla, a former Indian Forest Service officer and chief wildlife warden, points out a grey area in the law. "Currently, a farmer chasing an animal feeding on his crops can be booked for 'hunting' based on the definition in the WPA," he says. Pabla's record adds weight to his perspective—it was during his tenure that tigers were brought back to Panna, bison to Bandhavgarh and swamp deer to Satpura, reintroducing these species to habitats they had vanished from. He says the WPA should be amended to incorporate newer thinking on conservation, which includes ensuring communities benefit from wildlife.



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A related proposal has to do with the way species are listed under the Act,